smiled at me reassuringly, and took my hand again: but her fingers trembled against mine.

'He was all right,' I said, feeling that it was she who needed reassurance.

She smiled gratefully at me and pressed my hand. We walked together in silence until we reached the place where I had left my suitcase. One of my schoolfellows, Satish, a boy of about my age, had turned up with his mother.

Section-II



'Hello, Arun!' he called. 'The train's coming in late, as usual. Did you know we have a new Headmaster this year?'

We shook hands, and then he turned to his mother and said: 'This is Arun, mother. He is one of my friends, and the best bowler in the class.'

'I am glad to know that,' said his mother, a large **imposing** woman who wore spectacles. She looked at the woman who led my hand and said: 'And I suppose you're Arun's mother?'

I opened my mouth to make some explanation, but before I could say anything the woman replied: 'Yes I am Arun's mother.'

I was unable to speak a word. I looked quickly up at the woman, but she did not appear to be at all **embarrassed**, and was smiling at Satish's mother.

Satish's mother said: 'It's such a **nuisance** having to wait for the train right in the middle of the night. But one can't let the child wait here alone. Anything can happen to a boy at a big station like this, there are so many suspicious characters hanging about. These days one has to be very careful of strangers.'

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